

Slowing down to grow

BY HELEN CHEN

A VIRTUAL GROUNDS PROJECT

**"The three questions we
must ask when we are
building things:
To what end. At what cost.
At whose expense."
- Srinjia Srinivasan**



[Image Credit: Dress-Making Strike at the Labour Lyceum, February 25, 1931](#)

1.

THE PAST

The birth of
a city usually
predates
one's
existence.

Although
rapid urban
growth is the
hallmark of
the 21st
century, very
few people
living in
urban areas
have
witnessed, or
contributed
to the
planning of
a town, city,
or any
system of
civilization,
leaving
many people
with a bit of
an
asymmetric
view of why

a city
behaves the
way it does.

Living in a
world where
our survival
depends on
our ability to
adapt to new
technologies,
it makes
sense that
much of
urban
thought is
oriented
towards the
idea of
hyper-
growth.

One doesn't
need to look
far for
examples of
hyper-
growth. But
the one that
stands out
the most, for
me, is the
sleek, black-

and-white
office
building that
sits on 346
Spadina Ave,
where
generations
of
immigrant-
born
institutions
used to
thrive.

It was first
used as
residences,
then
purchased
by the
Labour
Lyceum, a
Jewish
worker's
union, in the
1920s. From
there, we see
it pass hands
to the Yen
Pin Place in
the 1970s,
and from

then on,
decades of
ever-
changing
Chinatown
dim-sum
restaurants
would pop in
and out of
place. Now,
as an office
building, it
has been
vacant since
its
emergence
in 2018,
serving as
nothing
more than a
modern
paperweight
on what
used to be an
area of
extreme
activity.

When we
witness a
city on the
decline, the

most
common
response
both from
the citizens,
and the
government,
is to
encourage
economic
growth. But
what
happens
when the
injection of
growth is
misplaced,
and ends up
becoming a
burden for
the
community,
like the case
of 346
Spadina
Ave? What
about cities,
or sections
of cities,
which have
declined to
grow, but

remain
healthy,
pleasant
places to
live? What
can we learn
from them?

Most
importantly:
are growth
and progress
intrinsically
linked?

(click to answer)

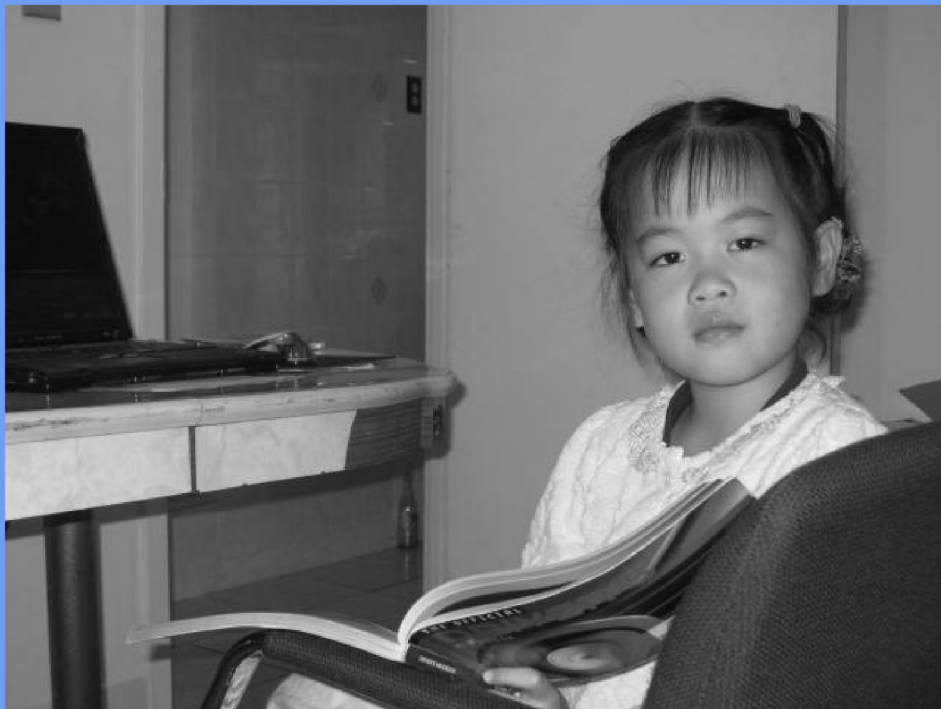


Image: Myself, 5 years old

My life as a
Chinese-

Canadian
immigrant
was one
seemingly
destined for
growth, at all
emotional
costs. Many
immigrant
families do –
we optimize
for a goal-
driven,
growth-
heavy
lifestyle
because it's
how we
managed to
survive, and
ensures our
survival for
many years
to come.

Many of the
parents in
my
community
struggled to

maintain a
façade of
non-
hierarchical
pleasantness
among their
Caucasian
coworkers,
who always
persuaded
them that
they were
'friends' or
'family',
even as the
racial divides
became
clearer. I was
told to steer
away from
White
people in
romantic
relationships
– not out of
a fear that I
would be
mistreated,
but out of a
potential
loneliness I
would

endure: in
their
opinion, ‘
*Chinese
people will
say the
painful
truths, but
Guai Lo
(White
people) will
only extend
a painful lie
further.*’

These
differences
in ideology
made them
feel
misunderstood
and isolated,
while they
continuously
told me and
my sister to
look up to
the very
population
they held
distain for as
a shining

example of
how to
succeed in
this new
world. Our
growth
meant their
stagnation,
but they felt
like it was
their
responsibility
to assimilate
us. So
reluctantly,
we grew.

The
insignificance
of certain
social
signifiers in
their new
Canadian
environment,
like school
rankings,
was also
strange to
them. An
unspoken
motto in our

house was
that what is
measured, is
managed,
and it felt
strange to
move across
the globe,
then have a
fundamental
part of your
life
diminished,
seemingly
not
important
anymore in
the grand
scheme of
things. You
get angry,
then tired,
then
complacent.

Yet, our
family's
situation is
not
uncommon,
at all – we
are but a

product of
the forces
that
propelled
globalization
and
capitalism
into the
spotlight, a
tiny,
emotionally
charged
consequence
of growth for
the sake of
survival.

And if
growth
means
survival,
then to
survive, we
must
understand
how to
quantify the
un-
quantifiable.

What are the
hidden
cultural

consequences
when we try
to quantify
un-
quantifiable
values?

(click to answer)



Image: the Simulmatics Corporation, the precursor company to many data-based empires like Google, and many parts of Silicon Valley

2.

PRESENT

The current
economy is
dominated
by silicon
valley's

'move fast
and break
things'
nature -
companies
are built and
destroyed
without
considering
what is
being
broken, and
what the
motives
behind
moving fast
are.

There is a
persistent,
ever-
growing
narrative
that each
newest
technological
advance will
be the one
to save us,
ignoring
advances in
other

'world-
saving'
fields:
public
policy,
politics, and
general
structural
reform,
among
many
others. We
have to start
asking who
is benefiting
from this
optimization
and growth -
often, it's
not an
advance for
society as it
is marketed
as, but
rather used
as a means
to achieve
another
end,
including
but not
limited to

mass
surveillance,
control, and
financial
gain.

Despite an
public
aversion to
corporate
power, this
tech-
dominant
form of
acceleration
still bleeds
into the
creative
world,
impacting
how cultural
products
and
destinations
are created
and
maintained:

the advent
of the
Digital
Artistic

Assistant,
more often
marketed as
a way to
create faster
and to push
productivity,
than as a
way of
opening up
new artistic
possibilities;

the city's
hidden
contempt of
the
seemingly
'mystical',
non-
existent,
and
therefore
non-
quantifiable
benefits of
cultural
heritage
sites;

It seems like
if no one is

around the
measure,
and
advocate for
the impact
of culture, it
gets
bulldozed
for the sake
of growth.

Growth
does not
always equal
improvement.
Growth with
an agenda
can be
shrouded as
positive
change, can
be another
arbitrary
human
metric that
was
implemented
because
somebody
felt
pressured to
show

results, to
grow for
appearances'
sake.

So
reluctantly,
we grow.

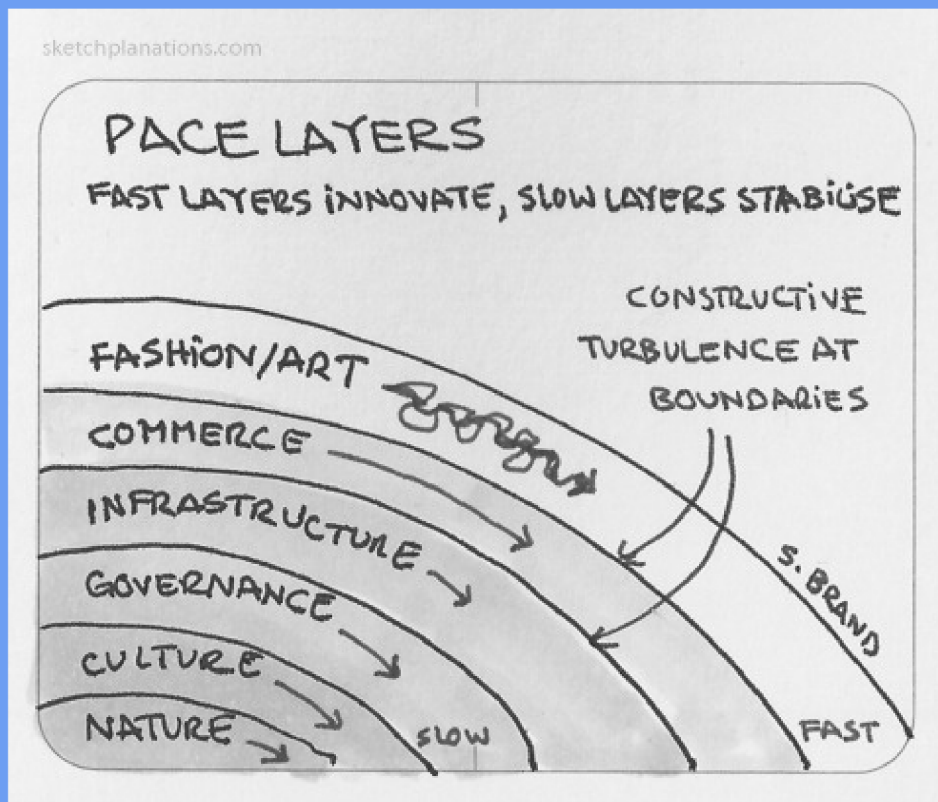


Image: the Pace Layers theory, a proposed system explaining how different aspects of civilization influence and interact with each other in 'layers', with the slower, more fundamental layers changing slowest over time, and the most turbulent layers changing faster.

3. FUTURE

What does a
world
without the
measurement

and
quantification
of progress
look like?

(click to answer)

Resources and Further Reading

[How to Do Nothing by Jenny Odell](#)

[How the Simulatrix Corporation Invented
the Future | NY Times](#)

[Radical Technologies by Adam Greenfield](#)

[Voices from the Valley by Ben Tarnoff
and Moira Weigel](#)

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